

Figure 4. Aparajita trampling Ganesha

Having said that, the Nalanda site museum, which displays less than 3 per cent of its stash from Nalanda and its vicinity, has several curious sculptures from the waning centuries of Indian Buddhism. According to the museum's panels, the Buddhist deity Aparajita is shown trampling Ganesh while Indra holds an umbrella over his head. The Tantric deity Heruka, whose crown depicts the Buddha, is shown trampling Shiva. There are other such images, including the Vajrayana deity, Trailokyavijaya, and the Buddhist deity, Vidyujjvalakarali. What might explain this dramatic and violent iconography that even flouted their ideals of non-violence? The reasons for this are likely rooted in the rise of new conflicts in the late first millennium between Buddhism and the popular new sects of Hinduism. According to Romila Thapar, 'Hostility between the Buddhists and some sects of Shaivas grew from philosophical and religious contestation, as well